

DSAT Practice — Cross-Text (Paired Passages)

25 Solutions with Reasoning, Trap Alerts & Insights

Q1. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Text 1 focuses on railways serving colonial interests; Text 2 acknowledges this ('exploitative origins') but adds that railways also boosted internal trade. So Diallo would say Owusu overlooked lasting local benefits.

WHY WRONG: B) Diallo does not deny colonial economic motivation; she explicitly acknowledges it. | **C)** No mention of Owusu's sources being outdated. | **D)** The construction workforce is not discussed in either text.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because it sounds like a strong rebuttal, but Diallo explicitly concedes the exploitative origins.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *'While acknowledging' is a concession signal—Diallo agrees with part of Text 1 before adding to it.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Concede + add = overlook, not contradict.*

Q2. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Whitfield says handwriting should remain essential; Zhao says keyboarding should be prioritized. Their explicit disagreement is about which skill deserves more emphasis.

WHY WRONG: A) Whitfield doesn't deny digital literacy's relevance; Zhao assumes it. | **C)** Zhao doesn't discuss motor activity and cognition. | **D)** Neither author discusses total time devoted to language arts.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because digital literacy is mentioned, but Whitfield simply doesn't address it—silence is not disagreement.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Find the specific claim where one says X and the other says not-X.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Handwriting essential vs. keyboarding priority = A.*

Q3. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Text 2 argues that species counts may overstate value because they include generalists, not the specialists most at risk. This directly addresses Tran's use of species counts to conclude gardens are 'meaningful refuges.'

WHY WRONG: A) Subramanian doesn't question the number of cities surveyed. | **C)** Pollination effectiveness is not discussed. | **D)** The ecological value discussed is specifically about pollinators.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because it's a standard methodological criticism, but Text 2 critiques what the data mean, not how they were collected.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *'Species counts alone may overstate' = the metric is misleading, not the data collection.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Counts ≠ conservation value because generalists ≠ at-risk specialists.*

Q4. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Text 1 dates migration to ~100 BCE based on archaeology; Text 2's molecular clock suggests ~500 BCE, several centuries earlier. So the genetic evidence suggests an earlier date.

WHY WRONG: **A)** Both texts agree the settlers came from North Africa; origin is not disputed. | **C)** Text 2 uses genetic data, which is specialized, not narrower in range. | **D)** Neither text declares any evidence unreliable or definitive.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because geographic origin is mentioned, but both texts agree it's North Africa—they differ on timing.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *'Several centuries before the date suggested by the archaeological record' = earlier date.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *100 BCE vs. 500 BCE = genetic evidence says earlier = A.*

Q5. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Osei supports compulsory voting; Petrov opposes it. Their disagreement is clearly about whether requiring citizens to vote is desirable.

WHY WRONG: **A)** Turnout trends are not discussed. | **B)** Both assume regular elections exist. | **C)** Both assume voting rights exist; the question is about obligation.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *C tempts because voting rights are mentioned, but the debate is about compulsion, not the existence of rights.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Support vs. oppose a specific policy = A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *For vs. against compulsory voting = A.*

Q6. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Text 1 concludes bilingual exposure doesn't impede development. Text 2 describes a temporary lag that disappears by school age. Since the lag is temporary, the author of Text 1 would agree it doesn't indicate lasting harm.

WHY WRONG: **B)** Text 1 doesn't question Text 2's evidence. | **C)** Insufficient exposure is not proposed in either text. | **D)** Neither text argues for monolingual education.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *D tempts students who associate 'lag' with 'worse outcome,' but Text 2 explicitly says the lag is temporary.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Temporary ≠ harmful; both authors ultimately agree on positive outcomes.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *'Does not impede' (Text 1) + 'temporary and disappears' (Text 2) = agrees it's not harmful.*

Q7. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Mori advocates for optical/laser signals; Duval advocates for radio waves. They disagree about which signal type should be the priority for SETI.

WHY WRONG: A) Neither author questions whether extraterrestrial intelligence exists. | **C)** Duval doesn't refute Mori's technical claims; she argues practicality favors radio. | **D)** Mori advocates for lasers, not radio; Duval advocates for radio.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *C tempts because Duval's argument could feel like a rebuttal, but she argues from practicality, not by disproving laser advantages.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Different priorities (information density vs. infrastructure availability) = disagreement about which approach to use.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Laser vs. radio = disagreement about which signal type to prioritize.*

Q8. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Walters says broadband drives GDP growth; Huang says the relationship may be partly reverse-causal (GDP drives broadband). So Huang would point out the direction of causation may be reversed.

WHY WRONG: A) Infrastructure cost is not Huang's concern. | **B)** Huang doesn't question GDP as a measure. | **C)** Huang doesn't deny broadband affects productivity; he raises a confounding issue.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *C tempts because it sounds like a strong counterargument, but Huang's point is subtler: reverse causation, not zero effect.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *'Reverse-causal' means the arrow of causation may point the other way.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Walters: $X \rightarrow Y$. Huang: maybe $Y \rightarrow X$ too = A.*

Q9. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Park attributes creativity to the DMN; Ruiz argues creativity requires interplay between DMN and ECN, and that without ECN the DMN's output wouldn't be useful. So Ruiz would say Park overemphasizes one network and neglects another essential one.

WHY WRONG: A) Ruiz accepts the DMN is active during rest; he adds that the ECN is also needed. | **B)** Ruiz doesn't question the validity of the neuroimaging studies. | **D)** Ruiz doesn't make claims about artists' creativity relative to the general population.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts students who think any criticism must target the evidence, but Ruiz's criticism is conceptual, not methodological.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Ruiz doesn't deny the DMN's role; he says it's insufficient without the ECN.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *DMN alone is not enough; need ECN too = overemphasis on one network = A.*

Q10. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Text 2 says 'internal factors alone cannot explain' Ottoman decline—acknowledging internal factors exist but adding external ones. This means Brennan recognizes Abbas's factors while insisting additional ones matter.

WHY WRONG: **A)** Brennan's analysis is broader than Abbas's in the sense of adding external factors. | **B)** They don't focus on the same set; Abbas focuses internally, Brennan externally. | **D)** Neither text dates the beginning of decline.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *C reverses the relationship—Brennan adds to Abbas's analysis rather than narrowing it.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *'Internal factors alone cannot explain' = I agree they matter, but they're not sufficient.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Agrees + adds more = A.*

Q11. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Udo points out that fragmented narratives predate the digital age by centuries (Tristram Shandy, 1759), and says attributing their rise to technology 'oversimplifies.' This means he would argue Lam overstated digital culture's role.

WHY WRONG: **A)** Udo explicitly cautions against attributing the rise primarily to digital experience. | **B)** Udo doesn't dispute Lam's definition of fragmented narrative. | **C)** Udo doesn't claim the technique is less common now.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *D tempts because Udo acknowledges digital culture 'popularized' the techniques, but he doesn't agree it's the primary driver.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *'Oversimplifies' = credits technology too much and literary history too little.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Predates digital age → technology not the primary driver → overstated = A.*

Q12. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Text 1 reports that cellulose aerogels achieved thermal conductivity comparable to conventional foam. Text 2 doesn't dispute this thermal claim—it raises a different concern (mechanical fragility). So both would agree on thermal performance.

WHY WRONG: **A)** Neither author calls for banning petroleum-based products. | **B)** Text 2 explicitly raises doubts about commercial readiness. | **C)** Text 2 focuses on mechanical properties as a problem, not as the most important characteristic.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts optimistic readers of Text 1, but Text 2 clearly states a durability obstacle to commercialization.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Find common ground: both accept the thermal conductivity finding.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Text 1 says thermal OK; Text 2 doesn't dispute thermal → agree on thermal = A.*

Q13. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Text 1 identifies artificial lighting as a threat to hatchlings. Text 2 describes amber LEDs that reduce misdirected movement, though field trials are needed. The author of Text 1 would welcome a potential solution to the problem she documented, with appropriate caution about confirmation.

WHY WRONG: **A)** Both texts discuss sea turtles. | **B)** Text 1 does not indicate the problem has been resolved. | **D)** Text 2 describes amber light as reducing disorientation, not worsening it.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *D tempts students who assume all artificial light is harmful, but the whole point of Text 2 is that amber light is less harmful.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Problem (Text 1) + potential solution (Text 2) + caveat (field trials needed) = A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Problem → promising fix → needs field confirmation = A.*

Q14. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Text 1 worries about losing 'ambient mentorship' in remote work; Text 2 reports that structured virtual programs achieve comparable satisfaction. Yoon would suggest these programs can replace the informal learning Thorn fears losing.

WHY WRONG: **A)** Yoon doesn't dismiss in-person mentorship's effectiveness. | **B)** Yoon doesn't deny any effect on professional development; he offers a compensating mechanism. | **D)** Yoon doesn't claim remote work increases formal training time.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because Yoon's data might seem to negate the concern entirely, but his argument is about compensation, not denial.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Yoon offers a solution, not a denial—'comparable satisfaction' means the gap can be filled.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Lost informal learning → replaced by structured virtual programs = A.*

Q15. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Text 2 reports that microlensing surveys found far fewer events than the primordial black hole hypothesis predicts, suggesting these objects can compose 'at most, a small fraction' of dark matter. This directly undermines Hamdi's proposal that dark matter may consist of primordial black holes.

WHY WRONG: **B)** Blake's evidence contradicts, not supports, the primordial black hole hypothesis. | **C)** Microlensing is precisely the test Blake uses to evaluate the hypothesis. | **D)** Blake doesn't claim Hamdi misunderstands Big Bang physics.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *C tempts because students might confuse 'the test doesn't support the hypothesis' with 'the test is irrelevant.'*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Fewer microlensing events than predicted = observational evidence against the proposal.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Prediction fails the test → hypothesis weakened = A.*

Q16. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Text 1 strongly advocates for mass timber's environmental benefits. Faced with Text 2's fire concern, the most consistent response would be to argue that the sustainability advantages justify continued fire-performance research.

WHY WRONG: **A)** Text 2 indicates uncertainty remains; Text 1's author wouldn't overclaim that fire risk is eliminated. | **B)** Text 1 doesn't argue for abolishing all building restrictions. | **C)** Text 1 doesn't claim steel/concrete are equally fire-vulnerable.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *D tempts because it's a strong rebuttal, but Text 2's evidence makes this claim unsupportable.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Advocate's best response to a valid concern = acknowledge the concern + argue benefits justify further development.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Benefits + continued R&D; to fix the problem = A.*

Q17. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Vaz wants more context (criticizes 'decontextualized spectacle'); Cole wants some context but not too much ('too much can overwhelm'). Both want context—they differ on quantity.

WHY WRONG: **A)** Cole doesn't advocate for eliminating context; he wants a 'balanced approach.' | **C)** Cole's reason (aesthetic experience) is different from Vaz's (historical significance), but they agree on the fundamental principle of adding context. | **D)** Cole discusses visitor experience, not institutional finances.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because Cole pushes back on Vaz, but Cole explicitly says 'a small number of carefully chosen details'—he wants context, just less.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Both agree context is needed; the debate is how much = A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *More context vs. some context = agree on principle, differ on degree.*

Q18. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Huang argues the green-space/stress correlation may be confounded by socioeconomic factors (wealth → both green space and better health). This directly suggests Fonseca hasn't adequately accounted for other variables.

WHY WRONG: **B)** Huang doesn't dispute the cortisol evidence from controlled studies. | **C)** Huang doesn't make a policy recommendation. | **D)** Huang's point is that wealthier communities DO have more green space, creating a confound.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *D tempts because it sounds like it contradicts Huang, but Huang's argument relies on wealthier communities having more green space—so this would undermine his own point.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Confounding variable argument: a third factor (wealth) may drive both X and Y.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Correlation ≠ causation because confound (wealth) = A.*

Q19. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Appiah argues the unreliable narrator serves a metafictional purpose (awareness of storytelling's constructed nature), which goes beyond Mendez's psychological realism framing. So Appiah would say Mendez underestimates the device's capacity to provoke awareness of narrative artifice.

WHY WRONG: **A)** Appiah's entire argument depends on readers recognizing unreliability. | **B)** Appiah doesn't agree that psychological realism is primary; he offers a different primary function. | **C)** Appiah doesn't claim Mendez has confused techniques.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because Appiah might seem to be merely adding to Mendez, but he characterizes the metafictional purpose as 'fundamental'—a replacement, not an addition.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *'Fundamentally metafictional' vs. 'primarily psychological realism' = disagreement about primary function.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Different primary function = understates the other function = A.*

Q20. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Mensah raises two risks: (1) moral hazard (political risk: reduced urgency to cut emissions) and (2) termination shock (physical risk: rapid warming if SAI is halted). Both undermine the viability of Solberg's proposed temporary measure.

WHY WRONG: **A)** Mensah doesn't dispute that SAI would reduce solar radiation; he raises other concerns. | **C)** Both assume emissions cause warming. | **D)** Mensah opposes SAI; he doesn't support it with a timeline modification.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *D tempts because it seems like a compromise position, but Mensah's objections are fundamental, not about timing.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Two distinct risks (political + physical) targeting the same proposal = A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Moral hazard + termination shock = two risks undermining viability = A.*

Q21. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Okonjo defines creativity as requiring intentionality; Brandt argues this definition is too narrow and that creativity can arise from accidental/unconscious processes analogous to AI's pattern recombination. Their core disagreement is about whether intentionality is necessary for creativity.

WHY WRONG: **A)** Brandt acknowledges human pattern recognition (unconscious associations) but doesn't attribute this view to Okonjo. | **B)** Both agree AI produces novel outputs; the question is whether novelty = creativity. | **D)** Gallery exhibition is not discussed.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because novelty relates to creativity, but both accept AI outputs are novel—the dispute is about what else creativity requires.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Necessary condition (intentionality) is the crux: Okonjo says yes, Brandt says no.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Is intentionality required for creativity? Okonjo: yes. Brandt: no. = A.*

Q22. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Costa's hypothesis predicts prey behavior changes when predators are present. Lindqvist's elk didn't change behavior, but he attributes this to elk having lost antipredator responses during 30 years without wolves. Costa could use Lindqvist's own explanation to argue the hypothesis isn't refuted—the elk just haven't had time to re-learn the fear.

WHY WRONG: B) Costa would not concede her hypothesis is invalid based on one study with an alternative explanation. | **C)** Study duration is not the issue Lindqvist raises; it's behavioral learning time. | **D)** Costa wouldn't claim wolves aren't effective predators—her hypothesis depends on them being threatening.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *C tempts because 'insufficient time' appears in both A and C, but the key is behavioral re-learning, not study duration.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Lindqvist's own alternative explanation supports Costa's defense: the hypothesis isn't wrong, the elk just haven't adapted yet.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Lindqvist's explanation (behavioral loss) = Costa's defense (give it time) = A.*

Q23. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Lang says credential requirements rose without corresponding changes in job demands (gatekeeping). Chaturvedi says requirements rose because workplace demands genuinely increased with technology. This is a fundamental interpretive difference: artificial barrier vs. real skill need.

WHY WRONG: B) Government regulation is not mentioned by either author. | **C)** Lang doesn't claim the trend is uniform; Chaturvedi doesn't limit it to tech fields. | **D)** Lang discusses effects on workers, but Chaturvedi discusses skill requirements, not employers' hiring costs.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *D tempts because it correctly identifies Lang's focus on workers, but mischaracterizes Chaturvedi's focus (skill needs, not hiring costs).*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Same trend, opposite interpretations: unnecessary gatekeeping vs. justified response to real changes.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Artificial barrier vs. genuine skill need = A.*

Q24. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Muller found no physiological arousal increase despite higher self-reported satisfaction, suggesting the satisfaction reports may reflect social desirability bias rather than genuine well-being changes. This means Muller would characterize Varga's interpretation as potentially reflecting participants' desire to appear consistent with social expectations.

WHY WRONG: A) Muller's physiological data contradicts, not confirms, the full picture Varga presents. | **C)** Sample size is not critiqued. | **D)** Muller doesn't dismiss the broader question; he challenges one interpretation.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because Muller 'confirmed' the self-report finding, but his physiological data undermines the interpretation that the self-reports reflect genuine well-being.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Self-report confirmed + physiology not confirmed = social desirability bias possible.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Says they feel better but bodies don't show it = maybe saying what's expected = A.*

Q25. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Herrera focuses on new varieties of English (Singlish, Nigerian Pidgin) as new linguistic diversity. Adjei focuses on indigenous language extinction accelerated by English's prestige. So Herrera sees new diversity being created while Adjei sees existing diversity being destroyed.

WHY WRONG: **A)** Neither author advocates replacing one language with another. | **B)** Adjei doesn't focus on agreeing about decline and disagreeing about rate. | **D)** Adjei doesn't contradict Herrera's claims about new varieties; he raises a different concern entirely.

■ *TRAP ALERT: D tempts because Adjei's argument feels like a rebuttal, but he doesn't deny new varieties exist—he argues they don't compensate for languages lost.*

■ *KEY INSIGHT: Same phenomenon (English spreading), different focus: creation vs. destruction of diversity.*

■ *FAST METHOD: New varieties (Herrera) vs. lost languages (Adjei) = A.*

TOPIC SUMMARY

TOP 3 MISTAKES — Cross-Text:

1. Treating Text 2 as a total refutation when it actually concedes part of Text 1 before adding a qualification.
2. Choosing an option about a topic neither text discusses (e.g., methodology critique when neither text questions methods).
3. Confusing 'would most likely agree' with 'explicitly states'—the correct answer may require inference.

TOP 3 RULES:

1. Read both texts' claims precisely; identify what each author says and what falls outside their scope.
2. For 'how would Author 2 respond' questions, find the specific claim in Text 1 that Text 2 addresses and track the nature of the response (concede + add, directly challenge, reframe).
3. For 'would most likely agree' questions, look for the overlapping ground between both texts.

EXPECTED FREQUENCY: 1–2 paired-passage questions per module. They appear more often in the harder adaptive module.